

IN THE NAME OF RELIGION Clockwise from left, Shastri with Kamal Nath; and with CM Shivraj Chouhan; 'Rudrakshwale Baba' Pradeep Mishra with Vishwas Sarang and Narottam Mishra

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THE BLESSED GO TO BHOPAL



Lahar MLA and leader of the Opposition Dr Govind Singh, who advocates distancing politics from godmen.

Early last month, Shastri made a significant appearance in Chhindwara, upon an invitation from Kamal Nath, the state Congress president. Nath, who represents Chhindwara in the assembly and has his son Nakul representing the constituency in the Lok Sabha, welcomed the baba with *aarti*.

Shastri was also hosted in Raghogarh, represented by former minister Jai Vardhan Singh. Congress leaders, sources say, maintain a connection with Shastri via Alok Chaturvedi 'Pajjan', their party MLA from Chhattarpur, who is said to be behind Shastri's rise as a godman.

The power dynamics between these godmen and politicians can be intricate. Since the discourses have a political motive, it is not uncommon for Shastri to be pressured into turning down some invites. For instance, he was reportedly made to say no to Narayan Tripathi, the BJP MLA from Maihar whose political group is opposed to Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

Even politicians from neighbouring Chhattisgarh, which has simultaneous polls, are flocking to Bageshwar Dham to enlist Shastri's support. "I have invited Shastriji for a discourse because his political and religious views conform to mine," says BJP leader Prabal Pratap Singh Judeo, the son of late Dilip Singh Judeo who had started the *ghar wapsi* programme in the state. Prabal is naturally eyeing a party ticket this time.

Given Bageshwar Baba's popularity, it is not surprising that the dates in his calendar are almost always booked. Shastri was also in Bhopal in April during Parasuram Jayanti celebrations, at the invitation of former mayor and BJP leader Alok Sharma, who has got the party ticket from the Bhopal North seat.

The landscape also features other prominent spiritual leaders such as Pradeep Mishra, a.k.a. 'Rudrakshwale Baba', from Sehore. Conservatively aligned, Mishra's mass appeal was harnessed in June by medical education minister Vishwas Sarang at a large-scale *katha* in Narela, his constituency. Nath has also planned a big programme in September of Mishra, who gives out rudrakshas for free.

Youthful Jaya Kishori, another sought-after preacher, has engaged with both BJP and Congress leaders. Recently, she participated in events organised by the BJP's Vikas Virani in Bhopal and Congress's Jitu Thakur at Mhow near Indore. Earlier, she was in Gwalior for